from the same plan. ‘Economic reforms with the human face’, the slogan with which the economic reforms started early 1990s has also the resonance of the People’s Plan.

The Sarvodaya Plan

After the reports of the NPC were published and the Government was set to go for the five-year Plans, a lone blueprint for the planned development of India was formulated by the famous socialist leader Jaiprakash Narayan—the Sarvodaya Plan published in January 1950. The plan drew its major inspirations from the Gandhian techniques of constructive works by the community and trusteeship as well as the Sarvodaya concept of Acharya Vinoba Bave, the eminent Gandhian constructive worker. Major ideas of the plan were highly similar to the Gandhian Plan like emphasis on agriculture, agri-based small and cottage industries, self-reliance and almost no dependence on foreign capital and technology, land reforms, self-dependent villages and decentralised participatory form of planning and economic progress, to name the major ones.[25] Some of the acceptable ideas of the plan got their due importance when the Government of India promoted five year plans.

By the early 1960s, Jayprakash Narayan had become highly critical of the Indian planning process especially of its increasing centralising nature and dilution of people’s participation in it. Basically, the very idea of democratic decentralisation was disliked by the established power structure, namely, the MLAs/MPs, the bureaucracy and the state-level politicians.[26] This led the Jayprakash Narayan Committee (1961) to observe against the centralising nature of the Indian planning. The committee pointed out that after having accepted Panchayati Raj as the agency responsible for planning and execution of plans, there is “no longer any valid reason for continuing the individual allocations subjectwise even to serve as a guide.”[27]

Disregarding the humble advice of the committee, central schemes like small farmers development agency (SFDA), drought-prone area programme (DPAP), intensive tribal development programme (ITDP), intensive agricultural district programme (IADP), etc. were introduced by the Governments and were put totally outside the purview of Panchayats.